

BUYING HOUSEPLANTS

Buying houseplants is an art. Always take a moment to consider where the plant will be placed, how it grows, how big it will get, and how to care for it. The plant may be in your home for years, so it's important to make the right decision. Here is my guide to buying wisely.

Check the label

Check that the plant label matches the plant you are buying. It's always best to keep a note of the common and botanical name so you can research it later for more information and detailed care instructions.

Assess toxicity

If you have pets or young children who like to chew things, you need to be aware that some plants can be harmful if eaten or have sap that can be a skin irritant. Always check before buying that the plant is suitable for all in your household—I have highlighted the toxicity of each plant in this book.

Choose the right spot

If you have a location in your house earmarked for a new plant, keep a note of the conditions in that spot and check the label of your plant purchase to see whether it is suitable. For example, a full-sun location is not the best spot for ferns; and a shady spot won't be ideal for a cactus.

Check for health

Check that the plant is in good health and keep an eye out for old plants. If the roots are growing out of the bottom of the pot, the plant is likely to be root-bound, which means it has outgrown its container. Give



Budding beauties

Buy your plant when almost entirely in bud so that it has plenty of energy left to flower at home.